

Muscardinus avellanarius

Hazel dormouse



Length 2½–3½ in
(6.5–9 cm)

Tail 2¼–3¼ in
(5.5–8.5 cm)

Weight ¾–1¼ oz
(15–35 g)

Location Europe

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



About the size of a house mouse (see p.128), the common dormouse is an excellent climber and jumper. Feeding mainly in trees, it changes its diet with the season from flowers, grubs, and birds' eggs in spring and summer to seeds, berries, fruit, and nuts in autumn. Dormice are the only rodents that do not have a cecum (a part of the large intestine), which may indicate that their diet is low in cellulose. The nest is made of grass in a thick bush or tree hole. Several individuals may live nearby and share the feeding area. They communicate using a wide range of whistles and growling noises. The female is pregnant for 22–24 days and has a litter of 3–6 young, although the numbers can range between 1–9, with up to 2 litters per year. The tail is bushy and its skin can detach if seized by a predator.



DEEP WINTER SLEEP



Most dormice hibernate deeply in winter ("dor" meaning "sleeping"). The hazel dormouse rests for about 7 months in a nest about 4¾ in (12 cm) in diameter—larger than its summer quarters. This nest may be in a burrow or under moss or leaves. It stores food both in its nest and in its body as fat, to enable it to survive throughout the cold season.

VARIABLE COLORATION
The hazel or common dormouse has yellow, red, orange, or brown upperparts and a white underside.

Glis glis

Edible dormouse



Length 5–7½ in
(13–18.5 cm)

Tail 4–6½ in
(10–17 cm)

Weight 2¾–8 oz
(79–228 g)

Location C. and S. Europe
to W. Asia

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



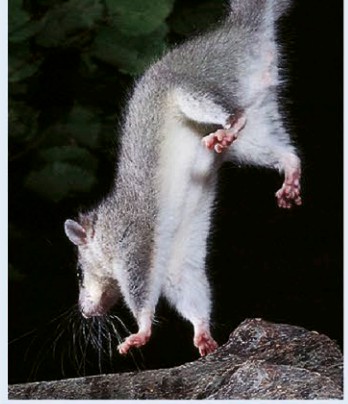
This species inhabits woods and out-buildings, nesting in tree holes or crevices in roofs and under floors. Native to mainland Europe, it was introduced to Britain in 1902. It is usually nocturnal but may also be active at dawn and dusk (crepuscular). As the days become shorter in autumn, it lays down fat to provide reserves. The edible dormouse eats leaves, seeds, fruit, nuts, bark, mushrooms, creatures such as insects, and birds' eggs and chicks. Like other dormice, it forms loose social groups and communicates by squeaks and twitters. While pregnant, the female is solitary, giving birth to 1–13 young after a pregnancy of about 25 days. They grow quickly and hibernate for the first time aged 8–9 weeks.

ONCE "EDIBLE"
This dormouse was kept in ancient Rome and fattened with extra food in autumn, to be served at the dinner table—hence its name.



SQUIRREL-LIKE LEAPER

The edible dormouse resembles a squirrel with its long, bushy tail, large back legs for leaping in branches, and semiupright posture. Rough pads on its hands and feet also aid climbing. It is highly arboreal and can leap over 23 ft (7 m) between branches. Its fine dense fur is brown or silver-gray with dark eye patches and white underparts.



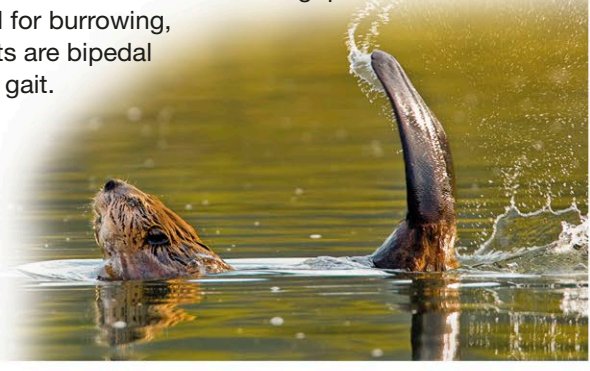
Beaverlike rodents

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Rodentia
SUBORDER	Castorimorpha
FAMILIES	3
SPECIES	109

Despite their superficial differences, beavers, pocket gophers, and kangaroo rats are classified together on the basis of anatomical details, such as skull structure and evidence from DNA. Beavers are large, semiaquatic rodents with webbed back feet and a flattened scaly tail and occur across the Northern Hemisphere. Pocket gophers,

kangaroo rats, and allies have fur-lined cheek pouches ("pockets") and are confined to the Americas. Pocket gophers are short-legged for burrowing, but kangaroo rats are bipedal with a bounding gait.

DANGER SIGNAL
By slapping their broad, flat tails on the surface of the water, beavers warn others of potential danger.



Orthogeomys grandis

Giant pocket gopher



Length 9–12 in
(22–30 cm)

Tail 3¼–5½ in
(9.5–14 cm)

Weight 17–35 oz
(480–985 g)

Location Mexico to
Central America

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



Like other pocket gophers, the giant pocket gopher digs a burrow system (lodge) using its strong, large-clawed forefeet. It feeds on roots, bulbs, and other underground plant parts and also comes above ground at night to forage for stems and shoots, which it carries to its lodge in its fur-lined cheek pouches. Normally solitary, during the breeding season the large pocket gopher forms groups of one male and 4 females. Two or more young are born to each female in a grass-lined nesting chamber at the lowest level of the lodge.

Cratogeomys merriami

Merriam's pocket gopher



Length 8–11½ in
(20–28.5 cm)

Tail 3¼–5 in
(8–12.5 cm)

Weight 16–25 oz
(450–700 g)

Location E. Mexico

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



The pocket gophers have a pocketlike pouch of furred skin on each cheek, for carrying food back to the nest. This species occupies a variety of habitats from sea level up to almost 13,200 ft (4,000 m). Its front incisor teeth are very long and can cope with many kinds of plant foods, from spiky cacti and farm crops (gophers sometimes become a pest) to fir tree needles and seeds. The upperparts are yellow, brown, or almost black; the underside is paler.